Project Proposal

Title:

Strengthening Forest Research and Extension Unit for NTFP Value Addition and Climate-Resilient Agroforestry at ICFRE-SDC, Chhindwara

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1. Executive Summary

This project aims to enhance the research, training, and field demonstration capacity of **Indian council of Forest Research & Education-Skill Development Center (ICFRE-SDC), Chhindwara** through strategic CSR support from **ICICI Foundation**. The intervention focuses on laboratory strengthening, NTFP value addition infrastructure, and the establishment of demonstration models for agroforestry and medicinal plant nursery development. The initiative will enable the institution to act as a nodal training and technology dissemination hub for the forest-dependent communities of **Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, and Chhattisgarh**.

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2. Background / Introduction

ICFRE-SDC Chhindwara is a premier research and extension institute under the Indian Council of Forestry Research and Education (ICFRE), working to promote sustainable forestry, biodiversity conservation, and capacity building in central India. ICFRE-SDC Chhindwara came into existence on 30th March 1995. It was declared as a Satellite Centre of Tropical Forest Research Institute, Jabalpur on 3rd January 1996.

Mandate:
1- Green Skill Development of forest dependent communities and front line staff.
2- To carry out research and training in NWFP, with focus on harvesting, primary processing, value addition and biodiversity assessment.
3- To disseminate HRM available technologies/processes/tools to user groups for conservation and sustainable use of forest resources.
4- To support the lead institute in research education and extension in the area of jurisdiction.

Core Research Areas:
1- Eco-restoration
2- Agroforestry models
3- Non-wood forest products
4- Production of quality planting material of selected species for improving forest productivity
5- Provenance trials of selected species
6- Biofertilizers and biopesticides

The region's tribal communities rely heavily on **Non-Timber Forest Products (NTFPs)** for livelihoods, yet face challenges in product development, scientific harvesting, and value addition due to lack of infrastructure and awareness.

Multiple areas of convergence were identified between ICICI Foundation's CSR objectives and the research-extension mandates of ICFRE-SDC. These include:

- NTFP value addition and marketing
- Agroforestry-based livelihood models
- Medicinal and aromatic plant nursery support
- Water and irrigation infrastructure for nursery and demo farms
- Scientific equipment for lab and extension training
- Firefighting and forest safety support

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3. Project Objectives

- Strengthen ICFRE-SDC's lab and extension infrastructure for NTFP processing and agroforestry.
- Establish demonstration units for medicinal plant nurseries and drip irrigation models.
- Equip the institute with scientific tools to conduct field-level quality testing and training.
- Expand value chain development of NTFPs across MP, Chhattisgarh, and Maharashtra.
- Promote technology transfer from research campus to forest-dependent communities.

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4. Project Scope

Inclusions:

- Supply and installation of lab equipment and NTFP processing equipment
- Development of nursery infrastructure and irrigation support
- Mobile van for outreach and training
- Renovation of Van Vigyan Kendra extension center
- Equipment for agroforestry and field demonstrations

Exclusions:

- Operational costs beyond equipment and infrastructure
- Salaries of institute staff
- Product marketing and sales activities (beyond training)

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5. Methodology / Approach

Implementation Strategy:

- Formal Request Letter form Director-ICFRE-SDC to ICICI Foundation.
- Procurement and installation of identified equipment in a phased manner.
- Hands-on training sessions for SHGs, community resource persons, and field officers.
- Documentation of best practices and results for future scalability.

Key Interventions:

- Bore-well and solar water pump system for nursery development
- Agroforestry and medicinal plant demonstration plots
- NTFP value addition unit with scientific dryers, pulverizers, oil extractors
- Supply of lab instruments (moisture analyzer, spectrophotometer, HPLC, etc.)

- Mobile van for training and forest extension
- Firefighting equipment for forest safety
- Van Vigyan Kendra renovation for training and workshops

Timeline:

Activity	Timeline
MoU Signing & Planning	Month 1
Procurement of Equipment	Month 2–3
Installation & Setup	Month 4
Training and Demonstration	Month 5–6
Monitoring & Mid-term Review	Month 7

6. Project Team and Roles

Team Member	Responsibility
ICICI Foundation tea	Project oversight, fund release, coordination
ICFRE-SDC Director & Team	Technical guidance, site implementation
Field Coordinator (assigned)	Monitoring, reporting, and documentation
Vendor/Contractor	Equipment delivery, setup, and maintenance

7. Budget and Resources (Indicative)

Item	Cost (INR)
Lab Equipment (Scientific)	₹ 25,00,000
NTFP Processing Unit	₹ 15,00,000
Solar Water Pump & Borewell	₹ 5,00,000
Agroforestry & Nursery Development	₹ 6,00,000
Mobile Training Van	₹ 10,00,000
Firefighting Equipment	₹ 3,00,000
Van Vigyan Kendra Renovation	₹ 4,00,000
Misc. (Transport, Documentation, IEC)	₹ 2,00,000
Total Estimated Budget	**₹ 70,00,000**

8. Risk Management

Risk	Mitigation
Delayed procurement or setup	Vendor tie-ups with penalty clauses
Community participation challenges	Mobilization through forest department
Equipment handling or damage	Training and handover protocols
Seasonal constraints (monsoon impact)	Pre-monsoon planning of installation

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9. Evaluation and Success Criteria

Success Indicator	Means of Verification
Installation and functionality of all equipment	Physical inspection, installation reports
No. of trainings and outreach programs conducted	Training reports, photos, attendance sheets
Number of SHGs/communities trained or supported	Beneficiary registers, feedback forms
Improvement in NTFP product quality and shelf life	Lab test reports, user feedback
Agroforestry and nursery model replications	Field visits, plantation tracking

Monitoring will be jointly done by ICICI Foundation and ICFRE-SDC team quarterly.

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10. Conclusion

This collaborative initiative between ICICI Foundation and ICFRE-SDC, Chhindwara, holds great promise in establishing a **regional resource and training hub** for sustainable forest-based livelihoods. By investing in scientific infrastructure and field-level demonstration, the project will empower tribal and forest-dependent communities across central India through **value addition, income generation, and conservation-based development**.

We seek approval for this CSR collaboration and look forward to your support in realizing this impactful vision.